CRO Compare

A free price-comparison site for small labs buying sequencing and cell-based assay services

Project overview · October 2026 · Status: working prototype, not yet public

1. The idea

Small labs, startups and academic groups often need an outside service: sequencing a plasmid, running RNA-seq, or testing a compound for toxicity in cells. They have no procurement team, and the prices are scattered across university core-facility pages, PDFs and quote forms. The big marketplaces are built for pharma buyers.

CRO Compare lets a small buyer type what they need, enter how many samples they have and whether they are academic or industry, and see every provider ranked by total price. For services that have no public price, one standard request goes to several providers and the replies are logged side by side.

2. The problem

- **Prices are hidden or inconsistent.** Many CROs publish nothing. Core facilities publish, but each uses its own tiers (internal, external academic, industry) and bulk discounts.
- **Listings are not comparable.** Some prices cover only library prep, others a full run with analysis. Search snippets and old PDFs are often wrong; while building the prototype, several prices read from search results turned out to differ from the provider's own page.
- **Small buyers lose time.** Collecting three comparable quotes can take weeks of emails.

3. How the product works

Feature	What it does
Search and filters	Search by service; choose academic or industry; enter sample count. Bulk tiers apply automatically (for example, a Sanger price drops at 95 samples).
Verified price cards	Each price is copied from the provider's own page, shows the date it was checked, and links to the source. Rates for a facility's own staff are excluded because outside buyers cannot get them.
Request a quote	One structured form (cell line, readout, compounds, design, timeline) produces a standard request to send to several providers.
Like-for-like scope	Offers that cover only part of the work (for example library prep without sequencing) are badged "partial scope", never marked lowest, and can be hidden.
Volume tips and cost curves	The card says when ordering a few more samples unlocks a cheaper bulk tier, and a chart shows total cost against sample count for each service.
Project planner	Add several services and see the cheapest total from one provider or by mixing providers.
Service guide	Plain-English goals ("check a whole plasmid", "find an IC50") point a non-expert to the right service.
Quote checklists	Each request includes service-specific questions (what is included, read depth, analysis, controls) so replies can be compared fairly.
Quote sanity check	A received quote is compared per unit with the provider's public price or the community median and flagged if it looks high or too low.
Turnaround and export	Turnaround is shown where the provider states it, with a "fastest" sort; the current comparison exports to CSV.
Service chips and guide	Nine services are one click away, with a "help me choose" guide in plain English.
Best-value tiles	Each service opens with its lowest total, fastest stated turnaround and the price spread, so the answer is visible before reading any card. Services with no public price offer one request to all providers.
Cards and table views	Switch between detailed cards and a compact comparison table; both show per-unit price, total for the chosen sample count, scope and check date.
Side-by-side compare	Tick up to four offers of one service to see prices, every tier, turnaround and scope in one table, with the lowest total highlighted.
Budget and location filters	Set a budget for the whole order, and filter by country and by core facility or company. Over-budget offers are flagged and never called cheapest.

Share, print, dark mode	Every view has a shareable link. The print layout produces a clean page with totals and full source links for grant budgets. Light and dark themes, and a phone-friendly layout.
Quote tracker	The buyer logs each reply and sees the cheapest quote.
Community quotes	Buyers can share a received price anonymously (no name, notes or contact details). Others then see the median and range for that provider, which is the first price data for services with no public price.

Today: 46 listings from 35 organisations across 9 services (Sanger, whole-plasmid and 16S amplicon sequencing, RNA-seq, cytotoxicity/IC50, plate-based cell screening, and three quote-only cell-assay categories): 34 with a public price, 12 quote-only, 10 flagged as partial scope. Every price was read on the provider's own page and carries its check date. The site is live as a static page, and the code is on GitHub. Real-user feedback, provider replies and a hosted community-quote backend are not in place yet.

4. Why it should work

A real gap

Existing marketplaces serve large pharma procurement. Nobody focuses on the small buyer who wants a quick, cheap, comparable answer. Core facilities and low-cost providers are often the best value for this buyer but are hard to find and compare.

A data advantage that grows

Public prices bring the first visitors. Each shared quote then adds real market prices for services that otherwise only have "contact us". That data is slow to collect and hard to copy, and it makes the site more useful as more people use it.

Low cost to start

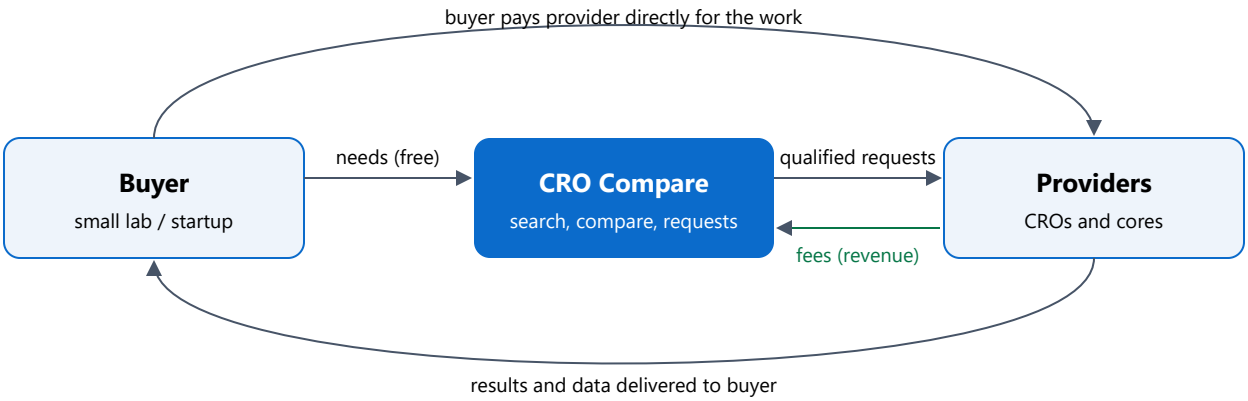
The site is static pages plus one small database. It can be hosted free, so it can keep running while it earns its first users.

Trust through honesty

Every price links to its source and shows when it was checked. Cards are marked when they cover only part of a service. That is the main reason a researcher would rely on it over a search engine.

5. Business model and money flow

> **Core principle:** searching and comparing is always free for buyers. Buyers pay providers directly for the lab work; the site never touches that money. The site earns from providers that want to reach qualified buyers.



Revenue streams, in the order I would try them

Stream	How it earns	Who pays and when it fits
1. Lead fee	A flat fee each time a qualified request is delivered to a commercial provider (for example $10 to $30 per lead).	Commercial CROs. Start once there are a few hundred requests per month.
2. Verified / featured listing	Monthly fee for a provider to keep its own prices current, show a "verified by provider" badge, and be highlighted in its category. Sponsored placement is always labelled and never changes the price sort.	CROs and small companies. Needs steady traffic first.
3. Price benchmark reports	Sell periodic market reports built from community quotes (median and spread by service).	Providers pricing their services, and funders. Needs hundreds of quotes.
4. Transaction commission	A percentage of orders placed through the site, with payment held until delivery.	Later, once trust exists. Adds payment, legal and dispute handling, so it is the largest build.

University core facilities usually cannot pay referral fees, so they serve as the free, credible backbone of the price data. Revenue would come mainly from commercial providers.

Costs

Item	Estimate
Hosting	$0 on GitHub Pages; roughly $5 to $10 per month if a small server is added for community quotes
Domain name	About $12 per year
Data upkeep	Your time: re-check prices each quarter (about 1 to 2 hours per 25 offers)

Illustrative scenario (assumptions, not a forecast)

Formula: monthly visitors × request rate × providers asked per request × share that are paying CROs × fee per lead. All inputs below are guesses to be replaced with real numbers from the first months of traffic.

	Cautious	Middle	Strong
Monthly visitors	1,000	5,000	20,000
Share who send a request	2%	3%	4%
Requests per month	20	150	800
Providers asked per request	3	3	3
Share that are paying CROs	50%	50%	50%
Fee per lead	$15	$15	$20
Lead-fee revenue per month	**$450**	**$3,375**	**$24,000**

> **Honest caveat:** the hard part is not the website. It is getting enough buyers to visit, and getting commercial providers to agree to pay for leads. Providers will pay only if the leads convert into real orders, so lead quality (a complete, specific request) matters more than volume. I would test willingness to pay with 3 to 5 CROs before building any billing.

6. Risks and how to handle them

Risk	Response
Cold start: no users, no community data	Launch with public prices only. Share in lab forums and with a few departments; ask early users to log one quote each.
Prices go out of date	Show the check date on every card; re-check quarterly; let providers claim and update their own listing.
Wrong or misleading comparisons	Note on each card what is and is not included; link to the source; include a plain disclaimer.
Spam or fake quotes	Rate limit and price checks are built. Median pricing resists outliers. Add accounts if abuse appears.
Conflict of interest once paid	Never let payment change the price ranking. Label any sponsored placement.
Legal / terms of service	Copy only public price facts, with the source linked, by hand. Review each site's terms before any automated scraping.

7. Roadmap

Step	What
Done	46 provider-verified listings; redesigned interface (service chips, table view, side-by-side compare, budget and location filters, print view, dark mode); 139 automated checks, including a real-browser suite; quote requests, tracker, planner and checks; feedback and "report a problem" on every card; community-quote and feedback backend written and tested (not yet deployed); user-research kit; provider outreach drafts; site live on GitHub Pages.
Next (free)	Deploy the backend to Cloudflare (about 10 minutes, needs a login); run 5 user sessions with the research kit; send the accuracy-check email to providers.
Then	Add providers in the categories real users ask for; run a pilot with 3 to 5 commercial CROs; apply their corrections.
Later	Test lead fees with a few CROs; provider-claimed listings; benchmark reports; evaluate commissions.

Prices in this document and on the site were read from provider pages on 7 October 2026 and may change. The scenario table is an illustration, not a prediction.